

AP EUROPEAN HISTORY REVIEW SECTION

THE POWER OF THE PRINTED WORD

A few books and pamphlets have had a far-reaching impact on the political, social, economic, religious, and intellectual development of the Western world since the Renaissance. These writings have stood the test of time in that they have shaped Western society for good or ill in modern times. The adoption of their tenets by Japan, China, and various other non-Western nations provides further evidence of their impact. While a case could be made for including or substituting others, a review of the books in this lesson provides students with a firm foundation for understanding major themes in modern Western history.

1. Francis Bacon, *Novum Organum* (1620): Bacon publicized the new method of acquiring knowledge through inductive reasoning, an approach to learning essential to the scientific method. Bacon and Rene Descartes stand out as prophets of a new world reconstructed by science. Bacon convinced 17th C. English thinkers to discard traditional ideas and look at the world from a fresh perspective, and not accept ideas based on traditions or dogma, primarily from the Roman Catholic church. Subsequent English experimentation led to the Industrial Revolution.

2. John Calvin, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion* (1536, 1559): Calvin provided a systematic theology for Protestantism. His work became the model for Presbyterians in Scotland, Huguenots in France, and Puritans and Separatists in England and America. The Calvinist ethic of the "calling" dignified all work as pleasing to God and encouraged a vigorous, aggressive activism.

3. Nicholas Copernicus, *On the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres* (1543): Copernicus theorized that the Ptolemaic-Aristotelian notion of the earth as the motionless center of the universe was wrong and suggested instead that every planet, including the earth, revolves around the sun. His work suggested a universe of vast, even infinite, size and brought sharp reactions from both Protestants and Catholics because of its contradiction of a literal translation of certain biblical references and because of its suggestion that the earth is just another planet rather than a specially created place in the universe. His work inspired other scientists to devise proofs of his theory.

4. Charles Darwin, *On the Origins of Species by the Means of Natural Selection* (1859): Darwin disputed the belief that each species had been created in a separate divine act and argued that all modern species of life had evolved from a few common ancestors. He documented evidence of evolution and theorized that evolution occurs through the process of natural selection, or survival of the fittest. His work created a revolution in biology, created new controversies in religion, and prompted

studies on Social Darwinism, the belief people in a society, and even societies themselves, compete for survival.

5. Sigmund Freud, *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900): Freud concluded that certain forms of mental disturbance can be traced to earlier, completely forgotten episodes of a person's life, perhaps even from infancy. Freud's new school of psychology made thoroughly upsetting suggestions about the nature of man as a less rational creature. His work forms the foundation of psychology today.

6. Adolf Hitler, *Mein Kampf* (written in the 1920's): Hitler's stream of personal recollections, ideas on racism and nationalism, theories of history, Jew-baiting, and political comment formed the basis for his propaganda. This book became the bible of Nazism during the World War II era.

7. Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (1651): According to Hobbes, people are the ultimate source of power, but they transfer sovereignty to the monarch by implicit contract. The monarch's power is absolute, but he does not rule by divine right. Hobbes believed people's most basic motivation are greed, desire for power, and fear of others, and he argued that without an all-powerful sovereign to rule them, people's lives will be "poor, brutish, nasty, and short." His book raised fundamental questions about human nature and influenced countries such as the United States to institute checks and balances in their government.

8. John M. Keynes, *General Theory of Employment, Interest, and Money* (1936): Keynes helped to revolutionize economic theory and policy when he advocated government intervention rather than laissez-faire to stabilize the economy. Specifically, he advocated increased government spending, lower interest rates, and lower taxes to encourage investment, increase employment, and increase consumer spending in a recession. During periods of recovery and boom, governments should reverse these policies to balance the budget over the course of a business cycle. (counter-cyclical policy) His policies guided economic thinking in most non-Communist nations for decades.

9. John Locke, *Second Treatise on Civil Government* (1690): According to Locke, people possess certain natural rights such as the rights to life, liberty, and property. In order to protect these rights, man establishes a government resting on consent of the governed. If a government fails to protect these rights, the people have a right to alter or abolish it. Locke's theory was used to justify the English, American, and French Revolutions.

10. Martin Luther, *95 Theses* (1517): Luther's religious principles, including the priesthood of all believers, and salvation through faith alone, sparked the Protestant Reformation and began the splintering of the Roman Catholic Church.

11. Niccolo Machiavelli, *The Prince* (1532): Machiavelli's reflection on human nature and government, based on his personal experience and his study of history, prompted him to substitute realism for idealism in politics. Machiavelli argued that a healthy state is unified and orderly, and it provides its people happiness, security, strength, and honor. Thus leaders are justified in using any means necessary, including cruelty, deception, and force, to preserve and increase the power of the state and consolidate their own power in government. His book destroyed the idea of a permanent social order established on the foundation of God's laws, led to the study of politics as a separate discipline, and influenced a number of European autocrats.

12. Alfred Mahan, *The Influence of Sea Power upon History, 1660-1783* (1890): Mahan's study of sea power, particularly that of England, convinced him that a country's strength on the sea largely determined its prosperity and position in the world. His book prompted many countries, including the United States, Germany, and Japan, to begin naval expansion in the years prior to 1914.

13. Thomas Malthus, *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798): The main idea is that population will soon outrun the food supply because population increases geometrically while the food supply increases arithmetically. Malthus argued that wars and disease would have to kill off the excess population, unless people limited the number of their children. Though improvements in agriculture prevented demographic disaster in the 1800's, rapid population growth in the 20th century has renewed interest in this theory.

14. Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *Communist Manifesto* (1848): The work provides a trenchant criticism of capitalism where, Marx says, social organization never kept pace with developments in the means of production. Marx viewed history as a series of conflicts between classes and predicted that the ruling middle class would be overthrown by the exploited proletariat. The result of the revolution would be a classless society in which the chief means of production would be publicly owned. This booklet provided the inspiration for the Communist revolutions of the twentieth century.

15. John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty* (1859): According to Mill, man is not restricted by unchanging natural laws which create a dismal society, but can make use of government to promote the greater good and minimize the pain in society (principle of utility). His revision of liberalism resulted in a softer, more humane liberalism which stressed the common good rather than the individual economic gain. His ideas inspired Britain, the United States, and later, other countries.

16. Baron von Montesquieu, *The Spirit of Laws* (1748): In his great pioneering work in social science, Montesquieu argued that

political liberty could triumph over tyranny if the legislative, executive, and judicial powers of government were separated. His work influenced the writing of constitutions around the world, including those of the United States and France.

17. Sir Thomas More, *Utopia* (1516): *Utopia* describes an ideal socialist community on an island off the coast of the New World. More's contention that flawed institutions, rather than the evil of human nature, account for problems of society was radical at the time but is generally accepted today. His city-state governed by reason, rather than greed and self-interest, provided guidelines for changes in education, penology, treatment of women in society, and economic organization in later centuries.

18. Isaac Newton, *Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy, or Principia* (1687): Newton created the first modern scientific synthesis of the physical universe. In stating the single law of gravity, he integrated astronomy of Copernicus and the physics of Galileo by means of a set of mathematical laws that explain how gravity governs the orbiting of the planets and the falling of objects to the earth. To work out the law of gravity, Newton developed calculus. He showed that all motion could be timed and measured, whether on the earth or in the solar system, and could be described by the same mathematical formulas. As the giant of the Scientific Revolution, he developed principles which were given practical application by later generations of scientists. This natural law concept impacted a host of other theorists that sought to apply scientific laws to society, religion, and economics.

19. Thomas Paine, *"Common Sense"* (1776): Paine's influential pamphlet attacked monarchy and inherited privilege. In a brilliant statement of the colonists' cause, he demanded complete independence from Britain and the establishment of a strong federal union. The pamphlet was read by Thomas Jefferson, George Washington, and hundreds of thousands of ordinary Americans who were inspired to support independence from Britain. See also Abbe Sieyes' *"What is the Third Estate?"*

20. Pope Paul IV, *Index of Prohibited Books* (1559): Good Catholics were prohibited from reading dangerous and heretical books on this list. This censorship of the press was used until Vatican II to suppress heresy and dissent but also served as a means of expurgating the obscene from literature.

21. J.J. Rousseau, *Social Contract* (1762): Rousseau's fundamental contributions to political theory were the concepts of the general will and popular sovereignty. Unlike Locke who believed that the social contract was between the people and government, Rousseau viewed it as a contract among the people themselves. Individual wills are fused into a general will of society. This common interest of society holds sovereign power. In becoming part of the whole society, one accepts the necessity to obey the general will, either willingly or by force.

Rousseau's writings made him the prophet of democracy and nationalism.

22. Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations* (1776): Smith criticized 18th century mercantilism for its privilege for private monopolies and government favorites and argued that reliance on free competition and private enterprise would better promote the general welfare. His philosophy of classical or laissez-faire school of economic thinking with its stress on the laws of supply and demand profoundly influenced economic practices in Britain and the United States.

23. Herbert Spencer, *Man Versus the State* (1884): In this work, Spencer applied the principle of survival of the fittest to social development. Life was a ruthless competitive struggle in which some were elevated to the top while others fell to the bottom. Only by elimination of the weakest in each generation could the species improve. Spencer's principle of Social Darwinism justified laissez faire and provided ammunition for opponents of late 19th century social legislation to help the weak. More than that, it was used by nations to justify imperialism, militarism, intense nationalism, etc.

24. Mary Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792): Basing her ideas on her own experience and the democratic principles of the French Revolution, Wollstonecraft became an early advocate of social and educational equality for women and argued that women could live happy, creative lives if they had better educational opportunities. A radical thinker in her time, she had considerable impact on British and American feminists in later generations.

Others

Lorenzo Valla, *On the False Donation of Constantine*

World History

Important Figures of the Renaissance

writers: Dante - Divine Comedy } wrote in vernacular;
Chaucer - Canterbury Tales } transitional works

Italian: Petrarch - Father of Humanism; Petrarchan Sonnet

Boccaccio - author; wrote Decameron

Castiglione - author; wrote The Courtier, a handbook for the "complete" man

Medici - leading family of Florence; merchants & patrons of Renaissance

Cosimo de Medici - began patronage of Renaissance in Florence

Lorenzo de Medici - last great patron of Florentine Renaissance

Sforza - leading family of Milan; patrons of Renaissance

Pope Leo X - ruler of Papal States; sponsored building of St. Peter's Cathedral in Rome

Pope Julius II - ruler of Papal States; oversaw completion of St. Peter's & the Sistine Chapel

Giotto - 1st great artist of Renaissance; humanized painting by using perspective & emotion

Masaccio - painter who used perspective, emotion and anatomical realism

Boticelli - painter famous for use of emotion and for bringing "gracefulness" to painting

Raphael - artist of High Renaissance; paintings

Leonardo da Vinci - painter, sculptor, inventor and engineer of High Renaissance; most famous paintings were Mona Lisa and The Last Supper

Michelangelo - great painter and sculptor of High Renaissance; used anatomical realism; most famous sculptures were David and The Pieta; most famous paintings are frescos on ceiling of the Sistine Chapel

Giorgione - great artist from Venice; landscapes

Titian - great artist from Venice; portraits

Ghiberti - 1st great sculptor of Renaissance; sculpted bronze doors of baptistery of Santa Maria del Fiore in Florence, known as Gates of Paradise (relief sculpture)

Donatello - 1st great sculptor to do free-standing sculpture; David

Verocchio - 1st great sculptor of equestrian statues

Brunelleschi - 1st great architect of Renaissance; designed some of Santa Maria del Fiore

Bramante - great architect of High Renaissance; drew plans for building St. Peter's Cathedral in Rome; dies before it was completed (by Michelangelo)

Pico della Mirandola - Oration on the Dignity of Man

Machiavelli - author of The Prince, a classic work on

northern (G) Gutenberg - introduced printing press (movable type) to Europe

(E) Erasmus - Father of Northern (Christian) Humanism; wrote In Praise of Folly

(E) Thomas More - northern humanist; wrote Utopia; believed human perfection was possible within framework of Christianity

(F) Montaigne - Developed the essay as a literary form

(S) Cervantes - author; wrote Don Quixote

(E) Shakespeare - poet and playwright; wrote Sonnets, Comedies, tragedies & histories

Jan van Eyck - Flemish Painter; early use of oils

Dürer - Flemish painter; used realism & symbolism

Holbein - Flemish painter; portraits (Henry VIII)

Brueghel - Flemish painter; landscapes

G = German

E = English

F = French

S = Spanish